state in welfare provision. Rather, notions of charity as moral citizenship are widespread and will likely have significant implications for the trajectory of state reform, as well as the mechanisms through which various actors exercise power during the term of the next government.

The chapter has five sections. Sections one and two offer a short history of civil society and the state in Myanmar and in Taungoo, respectively. Section three examines informal mechanisms of reciprocity and party politics in Taungoo. Section four brings the discussion to conceptions of the political, and the emergence of Buddhist nationalist groups in contemporary politics. Section five offers a snapshot of a rural family, particularly the role of religious and welfare groups in their lives and the evolution of their voting intentions throughout 2015. The paper concludes with some observations on what this sociology of Buddhist welfare implies for the development of political culture more broadly in Myanmar during the next phase of transition.

CIVIL SOCIETY: FROM SUPPRESSION TO FLOURISHING

The contemporary role of various non-state institutions in welfare, charity, and reciprocity in provincial Myanmar is tied directly to prior economic, political, and social policies, especially with regard to the regulation of civil society.[1] For much of the Burma Socialist Programme Party (BSPP) period (1974–88), non-state civil society was heavily censored and suppressed. Outside of a handful of authorized class and mass organizations (Taylor 2009, p. 373), all other community or civil society groups not linked to the religious sphere were suppressed or coopted by local military commanders and representatives of the BSPP, leading David Steinberg to comment that "civil society died under the BSPP; perhaps, more accurately, it was murdered" (Steinberg 1999, p. 8). This policy endured until the economic crisis of 1988, which sparked mass uprisings across the country and a coup from within.

The NLD victory in the 1990 election provoked an existential crisis for the new military regime. It embarked on a dual process of state- and nation-building throughout both the centre and periphery of the territory newly named 'Myanmar'. Despite the ongoing surveillance and suppression of overtly 'political' civil society, the continued degradation of the economy in the early to mid-1990s led to worsening livelihoods and welfare throughout